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FOUNDER RESOURCE

Data Room Guide

How to structure a lender- and investor-ready data room that reduces friction
and accelerates diligence.

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A data room is not a document dump; it is the operational proof of the claims in your narrative.

Investors form a view of management quality from the data room long before they form a view of the business, because the room shows how the company keeps its own records. This guide covers structure, sequencing, and the operating discipline that keeps diligence moving.

SECTION 01 OF 05

Structure

- Numbered folders aligned to diligence workstreams, so investor request lists map one-to-one onto your structure.
- An index document at the root with one-line descriptions of every folder and a change log.
- Consistent file naming: date, document type, and entity, in that order.
- Version control with superseded documents archived, never deleted; auditors and counsel will ask what changed.
- Access permissions tiered by process stage: teaser-stage visitors do not need employment agreements.

SECTION 02 OF 05

Core Folders

- 01 Corporate and legal: formation documents, cap table, board minutes, and material contracts flagged for change-of-control provisions.
- 02 Financial statements and KPIs: audited statements, monthly management accounts, and the KPI definitions document that keeps every metric consistent.
- 03 Commercial and customers: customer contracts, concentration analysis, cohort data, and

pipeline reporting.

- 04 Operations and HR: organization chart, key employment agreements, and option grant reconciliation.
- 05 Tax and regulatory: structure chart, filings, open items, and licenses.

SECTION 03 OF 05

Sequencing: Build in Investor-Priority Order

Populate the room in the order investors will read it, not the order documents are easiest to gather.

Cohort economics and monthly P&L reconciled to budget come first; they answer the first investment-committee question. Corporate housekeeping matters, but it convinces no one to invest; it only prevents them from closing.

SECTION 04 OF 05

Q&A Operating Discipline

- Route every question through a single intake channel with an internal owner; parallel side-channels create inconsistent answers.
- Hold a forty-eight-hour response standard, and communicate proactively when an answer needs longer.
- Maintain a living FAQ so the tenth investor gets the same answer as the first, in the same words.
- Log which folders each party opens; access patterns tell you who is doing real work before their next call tells you.

SECTION 05 OF 05

Best Practices

- Upload complete, executed documents; placeholders and unsigned versions read as unfinished housekeeping.
- Redact what is genuinely sensitive, but excessive blackouts invite more questions than they close.
- Refresh monthly financials on a fixed calendar day so investors learn the rhythm.
- Run a pre-launch audit against this guide with someone who did not build the room; the builder cannot see the gaps.

NEXT STEP

Put this to work with our team

This resource is part of the Keningford Partners founder toolkit. If you are preparing for a capital raise, sale process, or board decision, our team will review your materials against this framework and tell you where the gaps are, at no cost.

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